

Engaging People Through Dialogue

Chapter 6 — Communication & Engagement

Presented by:

Bibek Ropakheti

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- **Differentiate** between Monologic (telling) and Dialogic (talking with) communication.
- **Identify** the four types of dialogue: Debate, Discussion, Dialogue, and Skillful Conversation.
- **Analyze** the "Four-Player Model" of conversation (Move, Follow, Oppose, Bystand).
- **Evaluate** the role of active listening in sustaining change.
- **Apply** dialogic strategies to overcome silence and disengagement.

Monologue vs. Dialogue

Change communication often fails because it is monologic.

Monologue (Broadcasting)

- One-way transmission.
- "Telling" people what to do.
- Assumes the leader has all the answers.
- **Goal:** Compliance.

Dialogue (Exchange)

- Two-way interaction.
- "Thinking together."
- Assumes collective intelligence.
- **Goal:** Shared Meaning.

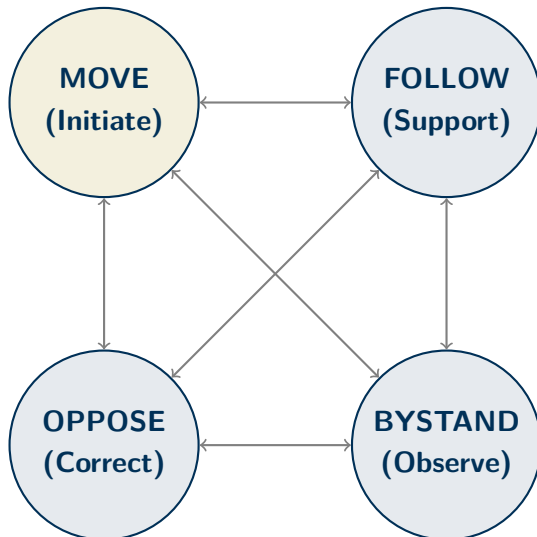
The Ladder of Dialogue (Isaacs)

Not all talk is dialogue. We must move deeper to create shared meaning.



The Four-Player Model

Healthy dialogue requires all four "moves" to be present.



The Power of Listening

Dialogue is 50% speaking and 50% listening.

Levels of Listening

1. **Downloading:** Listening to confirm what you already know. (Habitual).
2. **Factual Listening:** Listening for new data that disconfirms your theory. (Open Mind).
3. **Empathic Listening:** Seeing through the other person's eyes. (Open Heart).
4. **Generative Listening:** Listening to what is emerging; connecting to the future. (Open Will).

Barriers to Dialogue

Why is genuine dialogue so rare in organizations?

- **Fear:** Fear of being wrong, fear of conflict, fear of authority.
- **Organizational Silence:** A culture where employees withhold opinions to stay safe.
- **Time Pressure:** "We don't have time to talk, we must act." (False economy).
- **Hierarchy:** Power differentials shut down open communication.

The Abilene Paradox

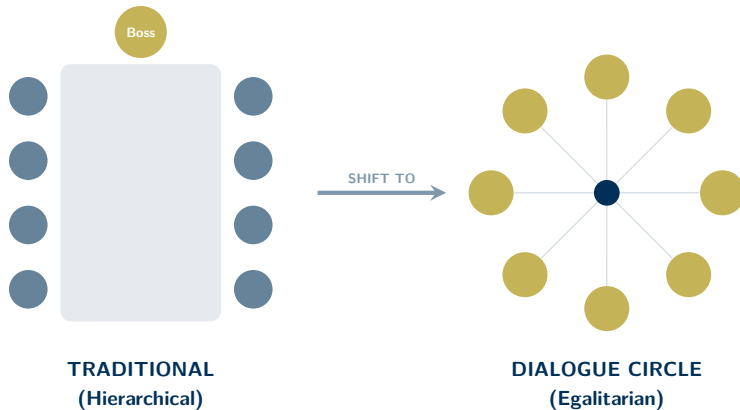
Groups taking actions that contradict what the members of the group privately want to do, because they fail to communicate their reservations.

Shifting the Mode: From Debate to Dialogue

Debate	Dialogue
Assuming there is one right answer.	Assuming that many people have pieces of the answer.
Combative: proving the other wrong.	Collaborative: working together to find common ground.
Listening to find flaws.	Listening to understand.
Defending one's own assumptions.	Suspending assumptions to explore them.

Creating Spaces for Dialogue

The physical and social structure dictates the quality of conversation.



Inquiry vs. Advocacy

Effective dialogue balances these two distinct behaviors.

Advocacy (Telling)

- Stating your views.
- "I think we should..."
- High Advocacy/Low Inquiry = **Imposing.**

Inquiry (Asking)

- Asking questions.
- "What leads you to that view?"
- High Inquiry/Low Advocacy = **Interrogating.**

The Sweet Spot

High Advocacy + High Inquiry = **Mutual Learning.**

Strategies for Promoting Dialogue

1. **Suspend Judgment:** Encourage the team to "hang their assumptions at the door."
2. **Ask Powerful Questions:** Move from "Who broke it?" (Blame) to "What can we learn?" (Possibility).
3. **Model Vulnerability:** "I don't know the answer, let's figure it out."
4. **Create Safety:** Penalize ridicule, reward candor.

Summary:

1. Engagement requires moving from **Monologue** (broadcasting) to **Dialogue** (exchange).
2. Leaders must balance the **Four Moves** (Move, Follow, Oppose, Bystand) to keep conversations healthy.
3. **Active Listening** is the most critical skill for change leadership.
4. Creating psychological safety allows the organization to access its collective intelligence.

Thank You

Questions?